

AP

MODI IS PLANNING A BLITZKRIEG OF RALLIES IN THE FINAL PHASE OF THE UP ELECTION WHICH COULD BOLSTER THE BJP'S TALLY SUBSTANTIALLY

SP launched a Dalit wing called 'Baba Sahib Vahini', aimed specifically at non-Jatav Dalits and scheduled tribes. One SP functionary claims that over 50 per cent of the 18 BSP MLAs and 25 per cent of its zonal coordinators and district presidents have switched loyalties in the past year-and-a-half to come on the SP platform. What has helped is that Mayawati had been a near-recluse in the run-up to this election; in fact, the SP suspects she is working in tandem with the BJP. Anyway, Akhilesh's campaign slogan is that the 'Samajwadis' and 'Ambedkarwadis' will together finish off the BJP. '*Bhaiya hi bharosa hai, nayi hawa hai, nayi Sapa hai* (Can trust Akhilesh, there is a new wave, a new SP)', he promises. The idea is to get close to 40 per cent of the vote share needed to get a majority—and any small accretion to its base would help. When it came to ticket distribution, Akhilesh ensured it was spread evenly across the new rainbow coalition he had engineered. An SP leader says, "We even reduced the number of tickets to Yadavs and Muslims to shed the M-Y tag." The final distribution saw 27 per cent of the seats going to non-Yadav OBCs and 22 per cent to Dalits. Yadavs and Muslims together got 30 per cent. The remaining 21 per cent was distributed across all other categories, including Brahmin faces.

On the campaign trail, Akhilesh is careful not to fall into any of the traps laid by the BJP. He waves away all talk of social engineering and caste politics, saying, "My focus is on *vikas*, not caste. We have distributed tickets in such a way that all castes and communities are included." The BJP tried its best to brand him as pro-Muslim, but Akhilesh did not join issue with it. He ignored the digs Yogi made in his speech in Ayodhya that his old SP regime ensured power supply during Id celebrations but not for Diwali. Modi went so far as to accuse Akhilesh of supporting terrorists and also linked his party's symbol, the cycle, to those who carried out the Ahmedabad bomb blasts, but Akhilesh refused to be provoked. There was no doubt that these barbs were aimed at disrupting the SP's formidable caste line-up and consolidating the Hindu vote through polarisation. Sudheendra Kulkarni, a former BJP ideologue now turned bitter critic who is in UP as a political observer, says, "This is gutter-level politics. While the effect of polarisation is still there, it is not as much as it was 2017. It is also because Akhilesh has moderated his party's image of being pro-Muslim."

Akhilesh does not criticise Modi as he wants to keep the issues local. Instead, he focuses on Yogi's performance—or, as he puts it, "the lack of it"—and mockingly refers to him as "*Baba mukhyamantri*". The brunt of his criticism is on the BJP government's perceived inability to deliver on jobs, improve the incomes of farmers and tackle the problem of stray cattle damaging their crops. At a rally in Unnao's Bhagwantnagar constituency, he shortened '*kala kanoon*' ('black law', a reference to the farm laws) to a handy 'Kaka' and spun a desi witticism: "*Kaka toh chale gaye, ab Baba bhi jaane waale hain* (The black farm laws are gone, now Yogi will go too)." Yogi hit back the next day at a rally in Ayodhya, pointing to the lawlessness that prevailed when Akhilesh was chief minister and how he had got rid of the mafia gangs supported by the SP. Yogi told the rally, "We have got rid of the *parivarvaad* (nepotism), *aatankvaad* (terrorism) and *jaativaad* (casteism) that SP symbolises. All they did was terrorise the people while the BJP brought genuine development." Yogi's announcement that he would provide 2 crore laptops and smartphones for students was greeted with the loudest cheers. The chief minister also has his own brand of charisma and is perceived to be hardworking and incorruptible—an image that Akhilesh has been trying hard to dent in the course of his campaign.

But while the leaders themselves may be trapped in permutations of identity politics, the populace is caught in a universal narrative of distress. Taking a dig at BJP rule, Annu